

We called for 18 PDA phones, representing between them perhaps the best replacements for a laptop that your money can buy.

Gorgeous Value

(Up To Rs 17,000)

Features

A few years ago, expressing the desire to buy a smartphone (let alone a PDA) at this price point would probably mean a trip to a psychiatrist. These phones aren't strictly PDAs, and do sacrifice on some functionality in order to keep prices within bounds, but at half the price of a traditional PDA, heck, who's complaining...?

At under Rs 10,000, the **Nokia E50** is truly light-weight, inexpensive and very compact. In fact, it is the slimmest phone in this category, and catches the eye because of its compact form factor. The colour itself (dull black) will not inspire much. The screen, though small, is brilliantly crisp, mainly due to the high pixel density (240 x 320). Although the camera is strictly so-so, this is forgivable for a business-oriented phone. The lack of Wi-Fi and a full keypad, and the ability to work with office documents (only document editing allowed, no creation) means this is more a smartphone than a PDA. However the price makes it a killer deal.

Nokia's E61 and E62 duo have had their fair share of attention. With a large, clear, and crisp screen, and an even larger form factor that some like and others hate, these phones are definitely aimed at users looking at affordable PDAs. The two look identical, and are extremely well-built—very solid in-hand. A brilliant 2.8-inch TFT with 16 million colours is the right way to go, and the



Nokia E50
Business is sleek!

only difference between the functionality of the two is the inclusion of Wi-Fi and 3G capabilities on the E61. The QWERTY keypad is awkward to use at first, but after a couple of days, we really got used to them. Nokia should have made this duo slimmer—these phones just aren't for jeans! A single ear-bud is provided, meaning music wasn't given importance. Battery life is stellar thanks to the huge 1500 mAh battery on both phones. For some weird reason, both phones miss out on HSCSD (High Speed Circuit Switched Data), a feature present on the more basic E50.

Sony Ericsson's M600 is definitely a winner as far as looks and form factor go. Compact enough to fit denims, it also feels substantial in larger hands. The gorgeous screen feels bigger (though it's not) than the E61/E62 mainly due to its vertical alignment (both the Nokias' screens are wider than they are long). Although the touchscreen works rather well and picks up even finger hits, we have two complaints with the stylus: it's too short to write properly with, and after a while, it gets loose and keeps falling out of its holder—not acceptable! The keys on the M600 work surprisingly well—we were initially dubious about having two letters on a single key, but it works well: tap the left side of the oblong keys and you have a Q, tap to the right and you'll get a W. It just needs getting used to.

The only Windows Mobile (WM)-based device in test, **HP's iPAQ 514** is their latest model; it tries to be a compact PDA by losing the QWERTY (typical on all other iPAQs). Based on WM6, this is a powerful PDA in the guise of a smartphone. It's built well, but feels built to a budget unlike other iPAQs, which, considering its price, seems fair. The keypad does feel a little tacky, but is well-

How We Tested

The following is our division of the phones:

Business Phones	Multimedia Phones
Upto 17,000	Up to 12,500
17,001 - 25,000	12,501 - 20,000
above 25,000	Above 20,000

Testing procedures were identical across the categories, except that the business phones were rated on their ability to work with

office documents and their wireless data transfer abilities. Weightages changed too—for example, multimedia phones should have better cameras than, say, business phones, so we did not assign too many weightage points to a business phones' camera. Conversely, a business phone should have multiple connectivity options and a good application bundle, but for a multimedia phone, this isn't as important.

We divided features into the following broad heads, while awarding points for the presence or absence of a feature. Subjective criteria were awarded points on a scale of 10.

Features

Physical specifications: Characteristics like dimensions, screen size, weight, and form factor were considered here.

Memory: Inbuilt memory, expandable memory, and their characteristics.

Other phone features: These include address and call book capabilities, and features like voice recording and voice dial. We also recorded talk time and standby time here (according to manufacturer-quoted specs).

Connectivity: This includes all possible connectivity options like Wi-Fi, Bluetooth, GPRS, EDGE, etc.

Accessories: What came bundled on each phone (applications) and inside each box (accessories)

business functionality: We rated the ability to work with different documents, the interface of the phone itself while accomplishing the task, as well as the bundled applications that aid the purpose. And finally, camera and media player features were listed.

We rated the build quality of the phones, more importantly, we rated ergonomics—from comfort to usability.

Performance

Signal and Voice Clarity tests: This is the most important test for any cell phone or business. Call quality and signal quality were looked at. We used two test zones—one was close to a window thereby giving a better signal (zone 2), and the other (zone 1) was right in the middle of our office, where even the strongest of cell phone signals die a non-mysterious death. We also tested hands-free clarity.

The Camera: We tested all possible aspects of the camera (if present) on each phone.

Multimedia: This test included quality of audio and video playback—basically a good test of the speakers, bundled headphones, and screen of a cell phone, aside from its processing hardware.

We also tested processing speed by multitasking, and Wi-Fi speeds were tested by transferring a 25 MB file from a laptop to the business phones. The laptop was a Core 2 Duo based, 1 GB affair connected to a Linksys WRT54G wireless router via RJ45 to ensure that the only bottleneck would be the wireless connection on the handheld's side.